

TeamWise: Exploring Virtually Embodied AI Facilitation for Video-Based Team Onboarding

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Figure 1: TeamWise explores how the virtual embodiment of an LLM-mediated meeting facilitator can support team onboarding. The facilitator joins the meeting as a video avatar and guides a structured onboarding sequence through real-time, context-sensitive interaction.

Abstract

AI-mediated facilitation has emerged as a scalable approach to supporting onboarding and coordination in newly formed remote teams, yet existing systems are predominantly text-based. To explore how video-based, virtually embodied AI facilitators shape team experiences, we present TeamWise, which joins video-based onboarding meetings as an on-screen avatar. TeamWise guides teams through a structured facilitation flow of low-stakes activities to foster rapport, mutual awareness, and shared identity. While the overall sequence of activities and facilitation goals is predefined, the facilitator's turn-by-turn utterances are generated dynamically by an LLM in response to participant input. We conducted a formative

study of TeamWise to refine the facilitator's design and interaction flow. We outline the design and protocol of a planned full-scale study comparing visual and voice-based AI onboarding that focuses on how and when embodiment influences early team interactions.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Interactive systems and tools; Collaborative and social computing systems and tools.**

Keywords

online meetings, group conversational agents, embodied AI, AI facilitation, participation equity, collaborative work.

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1 Introduction

Remote collaboration is common across educational and professional settings [28]. Yet early interactions in newly formed remote teams are socially fragile, with awkward silences, uneven participation, and unclear social roles [1, 4, 7, 12]. Limited access to nonverbal cues reduces social presence, making it harder to build trust, cohesion, and conversational flow [14, 24, 26]. Prior work shows that structured onboarding activities, such as guided introductions and icebreakers, can ease early team interactions [16, 19]. However, these practices typically rely on human facilitators, limiting their scalability for distributed and ad-hoc teams. We explore how AI-mediated onboarding may be able to address this problem since an AI facilitator may offer greater scalability.

Recent work has explored AI facilitators for early interactions between remote collaborators [22]. For example, *IntroBot* supports teammate familiarization by leveraging social media data to structure discussion, leading to improved trust and cohesion. This demonstrates how text-based agents can scaffold early team interaction. However, it remains unclear how well such a text-based approach might extend to video-based meetings, where teams frequently now meet. Video-based interaction affords additional conversational resources, such as nonverbal cues, immediacy of feedback, and shared visual attention [20], but also introduces different interactional dynamics and social expectations. In particular, the presence of an on-screen, human-like agent may simultaneously increase engagement and co-presence while also eliciting discomfort or heightened scrutiny due to its human-likeness.

In this work, we present TeamWise, a research prototype of a virtually embodied AI facilitator that joins live video meetings as an on-screen avatar to support structured team onboarding. We use TeamWise to examine how visual embodiment shapes the perceived presence, role, and social acceptability of an AI facilitator in video-mediated team onboarding. TeamWise guides newly formed remote teams through a short, turn-based onboarding sequence. Building on prior work that uses conversational structure to scaffold early team interaction [22, 23], the system leads participants through activities designed to foster rapport, mutual awareness, and shared identity. While the onboarding activities and facilitation objectives are predefined, the facilitator's turn-by-turn utterances are generated dynamically by an LLM in response to the team's conversation. TeamWise leverages recent advances in synthetic avatar technology that enable an AI agent to speak, gesture, and exhibit synthetic eye contact. We iteratively refined the design of TeamWise through an early-stage design evaluation to improve system usability, interaction flow, and technical feasibility. As a next step, we plan to conduct a controlled comparison study examining visual versus voice-based AI facilitation.

In this paper, we contribute: (1) TeamWise, a virtually embodied facilitation system that combines predefined onboarding objectives with real-time LLM-generated interaction in live video meetings; (2) an early-stage formative evaluation providing initial evidence that this design is feasible and useful for iterative refinement, and (3) a research plan for identifying the impact of visual embodiment in AI-mediated team onboarding.

2 Background and Related Work

AI-Mediated Onboarding and Facilitation. Recent research has explored how AI systems can support early team formation and onboarding by structuring social interaction. Chatbot-based systems such as *IntroBot* demonstrate how AI can scaffold introductions by recommending icebreaker questions based on shared interests, leading to improvements in trust and group cohesion [22]. Similarly, *BlahBlahBot* sustains engagement and conversational flow between strangers by recommending discussion topics tailored to participants' profiles [23].

Other systems surface personal information to support familiarity. For example, *Knowing Unknown Teammates* shares personal facts to help unfamiliar collaborators learn about one another, showing how attribution and transparency shape social outcomes [17]. These works position AI as a *social facilitator* that structures early interaction and lowers barriers to participation. We extend this line of work to examine how AI facilitation functions across different interaction modalities. While prior work has primarily focused on *what* AI facilitators do, we examine *how* facilitation modality—specifically *visual embodiment* versus *voice embodiment*—shapes user experience.

Potential Benefits and Risks of Visual Embodiment in Conversational Agents. Research on computer-mediated communication suggests that richer media support stronger interpersonal connection, with video-based interaction often associated with higher perceived social presence than audio-only communication [24, 27]. Building on this foundation, recent advances in synthetic avatar technology have enabled increasingly realistic visually embodied AI agents [8]. AI facilitators realized in this way may consequently feel more socially present and engaging compared to disembodied alternatives.

At the same time, it remains unclear whether these benefits translate reliably to AI-mediated facilitation, particularly in socially sensitive contexts such as team onboarding. Visual embodiment may increase engagement, but it can also inflate expectations of social intelligence, encourage over-trust in system guidance, activate social stereotypes, or raise privacy concerns in video-mediated settings [8, 10, 21]. Because onboarding interactions shape early impressions and group norms, these potential trade-offs motivate empirical investigation into when visual embodiment supports collaboration and when it may introduce unintended social or ethical risks.

3 TeamWise: An Embodied AI Facilitator

TeamWise is a virtually embodied AI facilitator that joins and supports newly formed teams in remote video meetings (Figure 1). TeamWise interacts with team members through voice-based interaction and limited nonverbal cues. TeamWise adopts the role of a facilitator that guides teams through a short, structured onboarding sequence to support rapport building, mutual awareness, and early coordination.

3.1 Onboarding Flow and Interaction Structure

TeamWise guides teams through a structured onboarding sequence designed to help participants speak early, learn one another's names, and establish common ground during an initial meeting. While the

activity sequence is predefined, the team is free to talk and engage as they like: the facilitator’s speech is responsive to the conversation, and aligned with predefined guardrails.

These activities are motivated by prior research on team formation and onboarding, which shows that early structured introductions, guided self-disclosure, and shared-goal exercises can improve familiarity, trust, and participation in newly formed teams [2, 9, 11, 15].

The onboarding consists of three short activities grounded in prior work on self-disclosure, memory, and group identity formation.

Activity 1: Name and memory chain (support name learning and early participation). Participants introduce themselves in strict round-robin order, sharing their name and an associated item (e.g., something they would bring to a party), while repeating all prior responses before adding their own. This creates repeated retrieval opportunities that support name learning under conversational conditions [11, 15] and ensures that all participants speak early in the meeting.

Activity 2: Fun skill sharing (support low-stakes self-disclosure). Participants share a small, everyday skill framed to avoid evaluation (e.g., “I’m good at cooking”). The facilitator models the task first, setting expectations for tone and response length. This framing supports low-stakes self-disclosure and reduces social pressure [2].

Activity 3: Shared preference consensus (support shared identity formation). Participants collaboratively identify one shared preference through a lightweight consensus process involving brief proposals and simple yes/no voting. By encouraging agreement on a shared interest, the activity supports the construction of a common group identity [9].

While prior work shows that early interaction structure, self-disclosure, and shared-goal exercises improve trust and participation in newly formed teams, TeamWise explores how to translate these principles into lightweight activities that can be deployed without trained facilitators.

3.2 Visual Embodiment Design

The visual design of TeamWise aims to present the AI facilitator as natural-looking and natural-sounding, leveraging recent advances in embodied conversational agent platforms. By using a high-fidelity synthetic avatar with synchronized speech and facial animation, the design seeks to increase perceived co-presence and enable a realistic examination of how visual embodiment shapes user experience during early team interactions.

Embodied Co-Presence. TeamWise appears as a visually embodied participant within the video meeting, rendered using Tavus’ Conversational Video Interface (CVI) [25]. The avatar communicates via spoken dialogue and is visually framed in a manner consistent with a typical video call participant, supporting seamless integration into existing meeting workflows. The current prototype uses a female-presenting, human-like avatar selected from available CVI presets, which we plan to keep constant across sessions to support experimental control and ensure that observed effects are attributable to embodiment modality rather than differences in avatar

identity or presentation. This was a controlled prototyping choice, not a claim about an ideal facilitator appearance; avatar gender and presentation may still influence trust, authority, and comfort.

Verbal and Nonverbal Behavior. TeamWise speaks using a conversational pace and casual tone, calibrated to allow participants sufficient time to think and respond without feeling rushed. Utterances are short and clearly phrased, and pauses are intentionally preserved to accommodate hesitation and reflection. This pacing is designed to support comfortable turn-taking and reduce cognitive load during early-stage interactions. In addition, the avatar exhibits a limited set of subtle nonverbal behaviors, including gaze shifts, blinking, head nods, and brief smiles. They are intended to approximate the nonverbal cues of everyday video call participants, supporting a natural interaction style without drawing attention away from the group. The nonverbal repertoire aims to increase perceived co-presence while allowing participants to remain the primary focus of the interaction.

3.3 Facilitator Persona and Interaction Tone

TeamWise is designed to provide structured, socially supportive facilitation while participating in interaction in a deliberately bounded and controlled manner. The system uses a structured specification to define the objectives, constraints, and guardrails of each facilitation phase, supporting reproducibility and a consistent interaction flow across sessions while still allowing real-time conversational adaptation.

Phase-Based Interaction Structure. TeamWise follows a predefined, multi-phase onboarding flow. Each phase specifies the facilitator’s goals, turn-taking rules, and constraints rather than fixed utterances. Within these boundaries, the LLM generates responses in real time, enabling adaptive interaction while maintaining clear transitions and reducing uncertainty during early-stage interactions.

Bounded Participation and Modeling. TeamWise participates in the interaction by speaking first in selected activities, providing example responses, and offering brief acknowledgments and summaries. These contributions are phrased context-sensitively rather than delivered as fixed lines. This modeling behavior is intended to set expectations for tone, response length, and level of disclosure. At the same time, the facilitator is constrained to avoid evaluative language, persuasion, or opinionated contributions, maintaining a neutral facilitative role.

Strict Round-Robin Turn-Taking. To ensure balanced participation, TeamWise enforces strict round-robin turn-taking among the participants. The facilitator addresses participants by name in a fixed order and advances only after a clear response is provided. This design prevents domination by more vocal participants and ensures that all group members speak early in the meeting.

Waiting Behavior and Turn Completion. Pauses, fillers, laughter, and restarts are treated as part of ongoing speech, allowing participants to comfortably finish their point and reflecting the dynamics of natural conversation. If there is uncertainty about whether a participant has finished speaking, TeamWise waits longer. This prioritizes conversational comfort and reduces interruption.

Low-Pressure Tone. TeamWise uses a friendly, casual tone and provides short, varied acknowledgments after each participant’s contribution. A rotating set of acknowledgment phrases avoids repetition and reinforces responsiveness without introducing judgment or comparison. Participants are explicitly reassured that hesitation or forgetting is expected and acceptable, framing tasks as low-stakes and non-evaluative to reduce social pressure.

Recovery Strategies and Guardrails. Explicit recovery strategies address common interaction breakdowns, such as silence, out-of-turn comments, or failure to reach consensus. In these cases, TeamWise redirects the interaction using brief restatements and continues the sequence without drawing attention to the breakdown.

3.4 Implementation

The system consists of a FastAPI backend for orchestration and logging, and a custom frontend built on the Daily video platform [6] for participant tracking and turn-taking. For the visual embodiment condition, we integrate a commercial avatar service, Tavus [25], to render a video avatar with real-time facial animation and lip synchronization. To avoid overlapping speech, we implement an *echo queue* that schedules prompts based on speech duration and detected silence. At runtime, the system generates facilitator responses based on participant input, interaction state, and the current facilitation phase.

3.5 Early Stage Design Evaluation

We conducted a formative qualitative evaluation to assess the feasibility of TeamWise, gather early feedback on participant experience, and refine the study protocol ahead of a planned comparison of visually embodied and voice-based AI facilitation. The study included three iterative remote video meeting sessions with four participants using the visually embodied version. Data came from researcher observations, brief questionnaires, and informal debrief comments, focusing on usability, interaction flow, and first impressions of the AI facilitator. Overall, the collected pilot feedback on TeamWise was positive, and participants described the facilitator as natural, friendly, and engaging. These findings are preliminary and intended to inform design iteration rather than support generalizable conclusions.

Validation of Design Intent. Participant responses suggested that the visual embodiment and facilitation style aligned with the intended role of TeamWise as a neutral, supportive guide. One participant wrote, “I was very impressed how natural the voice and the behaviour of the AI facilitator. Very natural,” while another noted, “I was very impressed by how natural the AI’s visual presence was.” A further comment highlighted that, “She was pleasant and the tone was friendly and that she used our first names, which gave a friendly atmosphere.” These responses suggest early acceptance of the avatar’s realism, tone, and interpersonal cues, and are consistent with perceptions of social presence and professionalism. Participants also engaged with the onboarding activities, which is consistent with the intended warm-up function, although this requires validation in a larger study.

Interaction Challenges and Refinements. The study also surfaced several useful refinement opportunities relevant to using embodied

AI in social settings. One participant noted that another group member did not fully understand a task instruction, suggesting that some prompts required clearer phrasing. Another suggested that the session ending should be signaled more explicitly. Some participants also reported brief initial apprehension when interacting with an AI facilitator for the first time. These observations suggest that, in embodied settings, even small issues in instruction clarity, pacing, or transitions may become more noticeable to participants. In response, we revised prompt wording, improved transition cues, and added a clearer verbal closing signal. These refinements are reflected in the current prototype.

4 Next Step: Towards a Controlled Comparison Study

Our early design evaluation suggests that TeamWise is sufficiently stable to support a controlled comparison of visual and voice-only facilitation. Next, we plan a between-subjects study examining how facilitation modality shapes early-stage team collaboration.

Study Design. The study will use a between-subjects design with 16 participants in four teams of four: two in the visually embodied condition and two in the voice-only condition. After onboarding, teams will complete a 15-minute collaborative AI ethics task designed to elicit discussion, joint sensemaking, and consensus-building [3, 13].

Data Collection and Outcomes. We will combine audio/video recordings, transcripts and system logs, post-task questionnaires, and open-ended reflections to examine interaction quality, discussion quality, and participation equity. Measures are being finalized through pilot testing, drawing on prior work [5, 22].

5 Discussion

TeamWise explores how evidence-based onboarding practices can be embedded into an automated workflow. Prior work shows that structured introductions, guided self-disclosure, and shared-goal exercises improve early team interaction [2, 9, 11, 15], but these practices are rarely applied consistently because they depend on facilitator availability and expertise. TeamWise contributes a system-level approach that operationalizes these practices into a structured, deployable onboarding flow that can be used without trained facilitators.

This framing highlights key differences between human and AI facilitation. Human facilitators are better at interpreting nuanced social cues, adapting activities in culturally sensitive ways, and managing conflict. In contrast, AI facilitators offer scalability, consistency, and accessibility: they can be deployed on demand, enforce structured participation norms such as equal turn-taking, and provide neutral facilitation in settings where human facilitation is unavailable.

TeamWise also raises questions about the role of visual embodiment in AI-mediated facilitation. We used the same human-like preset avatar across sessions to maintain experimental control and consistency, allowing us to isolate embodiment effects, and to align with prior work suggesting that richer visual representations and greater anthropomorphism can increase perceived social presence and co-presence in mediated interaction [18, 20]. We selected this

stable preset to ensure technical reliability and reproducibility during early prototyping. Because avatar identity can influence trust, authority, and comfort, exploring more diverse avatar representations remains an important direction for future work.

More broadly, TeamWise suggests a design direction for AI collaboration tools that focus on structuring interaction. Embedding facilitation patterns into automated workflows may improve access to structured onboarding, reduce coordination overhead, and help establish inclusive participation norms in newly formed teams.

6 Conclusion

This paper introduced TeamWise, a virtually embodied AI facilitator for structured onboarding in early-stage remote team interactions. Through this work, we explored the feasibility of a virtually embodied AI facilitator for structured team onboarding in video-mediated settings and used participant feedback to refine system usability, interaction flow, and technical robustness. Beyond the specific system, this work establishes a design-oriented foundation for studying AI-mediated facilitation in media-rich collaboration contexts. By making the role, presentation, and interactional capabilities of an embodied facilitator explicit, TeamWise provides a concrete platform for systematically examining how embodiment shapes user perception and social dynamics during team formation. Building on this stabilized design, future work will conduct controlled comparisons of visual and voice-based AI facilitation to investigate their effects on collaboration processes, participation patterns, and perceived interaction quality in remote teams – an increasingly salient concern as AI agents become integrated into everyday collaborative work.

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